

That familiarity lowers the barrier to trial in a category that is still evolving.”

However, Prasad of Bandarful insists that it is primarily the premiumisation of spirits that is driving growth. “It would be somewhere around 60–70% coming from premiumisation and 30–40% from coffee culture,” he says. At-home consumption is growing quite quickly. More people are experimenting with making drinks themselves and trying to recreate what they’ve had outside. The post-pandemic shift towards home entertaining has accelerated this behaviour, he explains.

Yangdup Lama, mixologist and Co-founder of Sidecar, The Brook, and Cocktails & Dreams, says that while coffee liqueur is still niche, it is definitely gaining traction. However, in India, few drink it neat; fewer still treat it as a digestif. “Its strength here is clearly as a mixer or flavour component in cocktails,” Lama explains.

RISE OF INDIAN BRANDS

For years, coffee liqueur in India was synonymous with imported labels, often sweeter and standardised. Today, a new generation of brands is experimenting with origin, roast, and flavour.

For Olson Pereira, Co-founder of Quaffine Cold Brew Liqueur, the logic was intuitive. “It was coffee which was going to be big because of our love for the drink,” he says. His approach departs from convention. Quaffine which was launched in 2022, uses less sugar, avoids flavour-masking additives, and relies on cold brew extraction to preserve the integrity of the bean. The result is a liqueur that feels more flavourful.

This emphasis on authenticity extends beyond flavour. Indian brands are increasingly



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foregrounding sourcing, drawing on beans from Chikkamagaluru, Kodagu, and the Western Ghats. Bandarful, for instance, positions itself as “farm-to-bottle”, with coffee being the defining ingredient. It is a language borrowed from food, but one that resonates in spirits. Rana observes that Indian liqueurs

are “becoming more interesting by experimenting with origin-based beans and less sugar.” He adds, “There’s a strong shift towards supporting and working with Indian products.” Adds Lama, “From a practical standpoint, sourcing is easier, logistics are smoother and costs are significantly lower